

AGE OF IMPERIALISM

The growth of European empires spanned several hundred years, and led to wars, revolutions, and rebellions by those who were unwilling to be controlled by foreign nations.

1500s

The Portuguese and Spanish start to explore widely, especially around South America.



Model of a Portuguese caravel

1565

The Spanish establish the first European colony in what is now the USA. The first English colony is founded 20 years later in Roanoke.

1756-63

The Seven Years War sees Britain become the world's largest colonial empire, gaining America and India in the global conflict.

1775-81

The American states win independence from the British after the American War of Independence.



The American constitution

1810-26

Revolution in South America leads to most colonies freeing themselves from European rule.

1858-1947

British rule is imposed on India after the Indian rebellion of 1857 against the British East India Company.

1880-1914

European powers seek territory in Africa, invading and colonizing the continent in a "scramble for Africa".

1945

By the end of the World War II, the empires of Italy, Germany, and Japan collapse.

1947

The British make the first move to end colonialism by granting India independence after pressure from Mahatma Gandhi.



Statue of Mahatma Gandhi

1956

Disagreement over ownership of the Suez Canal in Egypt leads to the Suez Crisis. Britain and France lose their influence around the world.

1963

Independent African countries set up the Organization of African Unity to promote their economic, political, and cultural interests.



Flag of the Organization of African Unity

European empires

AT ITS PEAK, THE
BRITISH EMPIRE COVERED
ONE-QUARTER OF THE
WORLD'S LAND AREA

As European explorers sailed around the world in the 16th century, they claimed "new" colonies for their home countries. Nations built empires overseas and many became rich. However, the native people in these new empires were often treated very poorly.

WHY BUILD AN EMPIRE?

Many European powers considered themselves to be superior to the rest of the world and thought they were the best people to govern, develop, and civilize other nations.



EXPLORATION
People wanted to find new territories and trade routes.



NATIONALISM
Nations wanted to demonstrate their power and compete with others.



ECONOMY
There was a demand for new materials and new markets around the world.



RELIGION AND IDEOLOGY
Religious groups wanted to convert more people to Christianity.

BIGGEST EMPIRES

At their peak, some empires covered millions of square kilometres of land across the globe.

- 1 BRITISH EMPIRE**
33.7 million sq km (13 million sq miles) in 1922.
- 2 SPANISH EMPIRE**
19.4 million sq km (7.5 million sq miles) in 1740.
- 3 FRENCH EMPIRE**
12.9 million sq km (5 million sq miles) in 1938.
- 4 PORTUGUESE EMPIRE**
10.4 million sq km (4 million sq miles) in 1821.
- 5 ITALIAN EMPIRE**
3.6 million sq km (1.4 million sq miles) in 1942.

